Reflective Paper

Design Thinking for Innovation

Topic	Promoting Responsible Drinking in Bars — Implementing Help Buttons
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Introduction

The Design Thinking for Innovation course significantly deepened and transformed my understanding of design thinking. Previously, I had been introduced to it during a Learning and Development workshop at Deloitte, so I knew it as a structured creative problem-solving method. Through this course, however, the process became much more vivid and practical as I experienced the stages of Empathize, Define, Ideate, Prototype, and Test in a complete project cycle.

Evolving & Understanding of Design Thinking

At the start, design thinking felt like a set of tools; by the end, it became a mindset grounded in curiosity, empathy, and iteration. Learning how design has evolved from focusing on form to addressing complex human-centred problems helped me see why it is so crucial today. Instead of jumping quickly to answers, I learned to stay with ambiguity, explore user perspectives, and let insights guide decisions. This shift also highlighted how structure (such as the double diamond) can support, rather than restrict, creativity.

Challenges and Team Dynamics

Some of my biggest challenges related to team dynamics rather than the methods themselves. Our group had many interesting ideas we could have pursued, but often gravitated toward options that felt easiest to execute instead of the most imaginative. This tension between practicality and creativity made me realise how strongly group mindsets influence the level of innovation. I personally would have preferred to work with more openly creative personas than rigid thinkers, especially in a course designed to encourage experimentation. Another challenge was narrowing down the many potential solutions to one clear direction, which at times felt like sacrificing good ideas in order to move forward.

Group Project: Responsible Drinking and Help Buttons

The group project, “Promoting Responsible Drinking in Bars — Implementing Help Buttons”, provided a concrete context in which to apply design thinking. Using the double diamond framework, we initially diverged widely, considering several interventions such as awareness campaigns, staff-training programmes, and digital tools before focusing on a help-button system. My main responsibilities were developing the value proposition and creating wireframes. Working on the

value proposition gave me a holistic view of how the solution could support bar guests, staff, and owners by addressing their jobs, pains, and gains. Translating this into wireframes showed me the practical implications of our idea: where buttons would sit, how notifications would appear, and how staff might respond. This made me appreciate prototyping as a crucial phase where concepts become testable experiences rather than abstract intentions. Although our professor appreciated the socially responsible nature of the concept, he also noted that the course emphasised creativity and that our team could have pushed the idea further. This feedback reminded me that even socially impactful ideas benefit from more playful and experimental exploration.

Stakeholder Interview and Key Insights

My individual stakeholder interview was one of the most memorable elements of the project. Instead of speaking to bar staff or students, I interviewed a General Practitioner in London who has been practising for fifty years. I carried out the interview in a podcast-style format, which made the conversation engaging and natural. He explained how alcohol affects behaviour, judgement, and aggression from a medical perspective. The most powerful insight he shared was the importance of avoiding physical force when handling drunk individuals; instead, he recommended isolating them from conflict, de-escalating the situation, and escorting them safely to a secure space. This perspective directly influenced our design. We shaped the help-button system as a non-violent, supportive mechanism where guests or bystanders can discreetly request assistance, and staff focus on safely managing situations rather than confronting people aggressively. The interview challenged my assumption that controlling disruptive drinkers required strong confrontation, and it reinforced the need to design for safety, dignity, and harm reduction.

Failures, Emotions, and Learning Moments

There were moments that felt like failures or missed opportunities. As a team, we generated many potential solutions and struggled to narrow them down, which caused confusion and slowed progress. We also realised, somewhat late, that we had not fully embraced some of the more playful prototyping techniques encouraged in class. Even though our prototype was creative, I felt we could have experimented more with storytelling, role-play, or interactive formats. These experiences taught me the importance of prioritisation, timeboxing, and protecting creative risk-taking within collaborative projects. On the emotional side, the stakeholder interview stands out as a particularly positive experience. Conducting it in a podcast style was fun and boosted my confidence in engaging with experts. Presenting our prototype was another exciting moment, as it turned the help-button system from an idea into something tangible that others could see, question, and improve.

Key Take-aways and Future Application

My main take-aways from the course cluster around three themes. First, innovation is less about a single brilliant idea and more about structuring creativity through iterative cycles of research, ideation, and testing. Second, prototyping is a mindset: creating early, rough versions—whether wireframes, physical models, or role-plays—is essential to learning how a solution truly works. Third, empathy and responsibility must sit at the heart of design, especially in sensitive contexts like alcohol consumption and public safety. Going forward, I plan to use design thinking in both personal and professional contexts. For my content creation, I want to apply empathy interviews, rapid prototyping, and feedback loops to develop formats that genuinely resonate with audiences. As a future brand strategist, I see design thinking as a powerful approach to align user insights, business goals, and creative expression. Overall, this course did more than teach me a framework; it reshaped how I approach problems, collaborate with others, and imagine solutions.